NovaCart Support Playbook: Returns & Refunds

Category: Returns & Refunds | **Document ID:** SOP-OPS-RR-02 | **Version:** 2026.4 | **Scope:** Tier 1-3 Support

Section 1: Reverse Logistics Policy Framework & Category Eligibility

1.1 Purpose: This policy governs reverse logistics management, customer return approvals, doorstep quality check (DQC) parameters, and automated financial settlements across all product categories sold on NovaCart.

1.2 Category-Specific Return Windows & Constraints

Product Category	Return Window	Condition & Packaging Criteria	Permitted Remedy Types
Fashion & Apparel	14 Days	Unworn, unwashed, brand tags intact, original polybag.	Refund to Source, Wallet, or Size/Color Exchange.
Consumer Electronics	7 Days	Original box, serial numbers matching invoice, all accessories.	Technical replacement or refund post-technician diagnostic.
Large Home Appliances	10 Days	Uninstalled, original polystyrene packaging, all manuals.	Brand technician on-site inspection mandatory before pickup.
Personal Care & Beauty	Non-Returnable	Hygiene-sealed items cannot be returned once unsealed.	Refund/Replacement only if received broken, expired, or leaking.

1.3 Return Initiation Channels

- **Customer Self-Service App:** Self-guided initiation via orders dashboard. System requests mandatory photographic upload for damaged or defective items.
- **Agent-Assisted CRM Override:** CSRs possess authorization to initiate out-of-policy returns up to 3 days past standard window for accounts maintaining high trust scores (Trust Metric >= 85).

> ***Policy Guardrail:*** *Underwear, swimwear, earrings, opened consumable vitamins, and downloadable software licenses are strictly non-returnable under international hygiene and digital copyright protocols.*

Section 2: Doorstep Quality Check (DQC) & Reverse Transportation

2.1 Doorstep Quality Verification Architecture: NovaCart operates an active DQC protocol where last-mile logistics executives inspect returned merchandise before accepting custody, minimizing reverse shipping overhead for fraudulent items.

2.2 Doorstep Inspection Protocols by Category

- **Smartphones & Laptops:** Agent must verify IMEI/Serial number against digital invoice, verify screen is free from cracks, confirm iCloud/Google accounts are logged out, and verify device powers on.
- **Designer Clothing & Footwear:** Verify brand barcode tag is attached via factory plastic barb, verify soles are clean without street wear, inspect fabric underarms and collars for perfume or deodorant marks.
- **Power Tools & Small Appliances:** Inspect motor casing for drop damage, verify power cord is intact, check inclusion of all chucks, blades, and adapters listed on package.

2.3 Doorstep Rejection Workflow

Failure Trigger	Driver Action	System Logging	CSR Escalation Script
Tag Missing / Removed	Driver declines pickup handoff.	Status: `DQC_REJECT_NO_TAG`	Explain tags are required to establish pristine merchant condition.
Serial Mismatch	Driver photographs box & device serial.	Status: `DQC_REJECT_SERIAL_FAIL`	Advise customer that item submitted does not match dispatched unit.
Device Locked / Passcode	Driver allows 5 min for user reset.	Status: `DQC_REJECT_DEVICE_LOCK`	Guide customer through factory wipe before rebooking return.
Customer Dispute on Rejection	Driver flags ticket to hub lead.	Customer service ticket auto-opened.	Request photographic evidence upload from customer for manual audit.

Section 3: Warehouse Inbound Audit, Grading & Fraud Mitigation

3.1 Warehouse Secondary Inbound Inspection: Consignments passing DQC undergo secondary optical barcode scanning and diagnostic verification at centralized NovaCart Reverse Logistics Hubs (RLHs) within 48 hours of intake.

3.2 Grading Classifications & Disposition Mapping

- **Grade A (Factory Mint):** Packaging pristine, seals intact. Restocked directly into active merchant inventory within 12 hours.
- **Grade B (Open Box / Outer Damage):** Packaging torn or opened; product flawless. Routed to NovaCart Warehouse Deals liquidation portal at 15-25% markdown.
- **Grade C (Functional Defect / Missing Part):** Routed to certified refurbishment facility or vendor return-to-vendor (RTV) line.
- **Grade F (Fraud / Brick-in-Box / Counterfeit Return):** Impounded immediately. Triggers automated Security Incident Report.

3.3 Return Abuse and Fraud Detection Protocol (RAF-D)

Risk Indicator	Behavioral Pattern	Account Impact	Mitigation Action
High Return Velocity	Return rate exceeding 40% over 90 days with >15 orders.	Account placed under DQC strict enforcement.	Warning banner displayed on app; restrict cash refunds to wallet.
Wardrobing	Recurring apparel returns showing perfume/creasing traces.	Apparel category return rights suspended 90d.	Automated rejection of future apparel claims without video proof.
Phantom Return	Tracking shows return label scanned, but box contains paper weights.	Immediate account suspension and fraud log.	File police incident report; recover funds via card network.
Serial Swap	Old device returned in new packaging.	Account terminated; serial blacklisted with OEM.	Evidence dossier forwarded to merchant legal department.

Section 4: Financial Settlements, Gateway Timelines & Discretionary Credits

4.1 Settlement Architecture: Refunds are triggered either immediately upon successful Doorstep Quality Check (Instant Refund Mode for Tier-1 accounts) or following warehouse physical audit (Standard Mode).

4.2 Payment Gateway Refund Timelines

Original Payment Instrument	Processing Mechanism	Standard Gateway SLA	Customer Bank Settlement Cycle
NovaCart Wallet / Store Credit	Internal Ledger Credit	Instantaneous (< 60 seconds)	Immediate reflection in account balance.
UPI / Real-Time Bank Rails	Direct NPCI / IMPS Transfer	2 to 4 Business Hours	Immediate upon bank notification.
Credit / Debit Cards	Card Acquiring Gateway (Stripe)	24 to 48 Business Hours	3 to 5 Banking Days depending on issuing bank.
Net Banking	Automated Clearinghouse (ACH)	48 to 72 Business Hours	5 to 7 Business Days.
Cash on Delivery (COD)	Direct Bank Transfer / NEFT	24 Hours from Account Link	Requires customer to enter verified IFSC/Routing.

4.3 Restocking Deductions and Late Return Handling

- **Late Return Acceptance:** If customer returns item 4-10 days past deadline with manager authorization, a 15% restocking fee is deducted from the gross refund total.
- **Discretionary Appeasement Authority:** CSR Tier-1: Up to $15 goodwill concession; Team Lead: Up to $40 concession; Operations Manager: Up to $100 concession for severe platform failures.

FixFlow AI - Customer Answer Guidance

Supplement to 02 Returns and Refunds SOP

Scope

Implementation guidance for FixFlow AI; not a change to the four-page NovaCart policy. Preserve all return eligibility, quality checks and gateway timelines in the original SOP.

Scenario 2 - shoes purchased last week

A general policy explanation is appropriate. Fashion and apparel have a 14-day return window, subject to unworn/unwashed condition, intact tags and original polybag. Customers can initiate a request in the orders dashboard. Eligibility and approval depend on verification; do not claim the return or refund is approved.

Expected customer-facing answer

"NovaCart lists a 14-day return window for fashion and apparel. If your shoes are unworn and unwashed, with their tags and original packaging intact, you can start a return request from the orders dashboard. The return is subject to verification. If eligible, the refund method and processing time depend on the original payment method and the applicable quality-check process. I cannot confirm approval or a settlement date for your order from this chat."

Timing claims

Do not state a single universal refund ETA. The SOP distinguishes quality-check/warehouse-audit triggers, gateway processing and bank settlement by payment method (Section 4). Cite the specific relevant passage when quoting a timeframe; do not present a conditional policy SLA as an order-specific guarantee.

Human approval

FixFlow implementation rule: actual case-specific refund processing of INR 500 or more requires backend human approval. General policy explanations do not themselves authorize or execute a refund. Fraud, legal threats and payment disputes remain mandatory escalation cases.

Citation and retrieval

Retrieve customer-visible Section 1.2 and 1.3 for eligibility and initiation. Include Section 4 only if refund timing is requested and the payment method is known or the conditional nature is clearly explained. Cite actual retrieved chunk IDs; never invent citations.